

1960-70

COUNTERCULTURE

In the mid-1960s, increasing prosperity and full employment fuelled a growing middle-class youth counterculture in Britain and the US. Young people questioned the values of mainstream society and drew together in an anti-establishment movement that sought to create an alternative society based on ideals of love, peace, and communal values. Known variously as “freaks”, “hippies”, or the “underground”, many experimented with psychedelic drugs, such as LSD, alternative religions, and sexual freedom as they sought to expand human consciousness and break down societal boundaries. This experimental culture was reflected in music, literature, and film-making.

Writers such as Jack Kerouac, Tom Wolfe, and Hunter S. Thompson explored new freedoms and themes including sex, drugs, and life on the road, while musicians blended folk, rock, and psychedelic styles to provide a soundtrack for the new culture.

The counterculture spawned some of the largest protests seen in America, as hundreds of thousands campaigned to “make love not war”, hoping to bring about nuclear disarmament and an end to the Vietnam War (1955–75). The new freedoms of the 1960s also fed into the US Civil Rights Movement, resulting in a series of important legal rulings that outlawed some forms of discrimination against women and African Americans.



KEY MOMENTS

1966 *Turn On, Tune In, Drop Out*

American psychologist Timothy Leary (*left*) released a spoken word album exploring his views on the meaning of inner life, LSD, and peace, among many other issues. It sparked San Francisco's Summer of Love in 1967.

1967 *Sgt Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band*

British band The Beatles embraced the counterculture, releasing an album about drugs, expanding the mind, and dropping out. They were the most popular band in the world at the time, so *Sgt Pepper* (*left*) exposed millions of listeners to hippy values.

1969 Anti-war protests

More than 500,000 people gathered in Washington D.C. on 15 November 1969 (*left*) to demand that US forces withdraw from Vietnam. Although it was a largely peaceful demonstration, the police attacked the crowd with tear gas; President Nixon refused to be moved by the protests.